

AI in the SDLC: Meeting Summary

Ascension x Insight Global · Overall discussion and Jose's perspective

Participants

Speaker	Name	Context
Speaker 1	Marissa	Insight Global
Speaker 2	Erin	Insight Global (led the discussion)
Speaker 3	Jose	Ascension, Senior Director (digital engagement)
Speaker 4	Sandeep	Insight Global (presented the solution)

Part 1: Overall Summary

Insight Global (Marissa, Erin, Sandeep) met with Jose, a Senior Director at Ascension, to discuss how to operationalize AI across the software development lifecycle (SDLC) for Ascension's digital engagement work (not clinical). Insight Global presented a context-layer architecture built on a knowledge graph. Jose pushed the conversation away from incremental efficiency and toward a fundamentally different delivery model. The meeting ended with Insight Global agreeing to come back with a bolder future-state vision alongside near-term wins.

1. Market reality check

- Erin was candid: no healthcare **provider** they work with is using AI across the full SDLC in a meaningful way. Most claims of being "AI-enabled" are pockets of vibe coding or AI-assisted QA.
- Payers are further along (Aetna, and parts of Optum). Other regulated industries, especially banking (Bank of America), have made much more progress.
- Ascension could be one of the first providers to do this properly, but there are few examples to follow.

2. Jose's ground rules and asks

- Focus on operationalizing AI in the SDLC for digital engagement.
- Don't just move bottlenecks around; rethink the process and delivery model.
- Explain what it takes (feasibility and skill sets) to move agents built on a developer's local machine into a cloud environment (Google Cloud Run, Microsoft Copilot, etc.).
- No product sales pitch (he referenced a previous Copado conversation). Marissa asked to still be able to recommend technology when the ROI is clear, and Jose agreed as long as it isn't the bulk of the meeting.

3. Insight Global's proposal: a knowledge-graph context layer

Sandeep explained that Ascension already uses Codex, but keyword/RAG search over Jira, Confluence, GitHub and Salesforce returns noisy context, so the output can't be trusted end to end. The fix is a layered context pipeline:

- **Layer 1, source systems:** Jira, Confluence, Salesforce / Salesforce DB, GitHub, Copilot, Google Drive.

- **Layers 2-4, ingestion and normalization (in code):** connectors pull each source into tables, then merge them into a universal data model.
- **Layer 5, unified JSON:** one large object-level JSON of everything known; stored in a Salesforce file for testing, later on Google Cloud.
- **Layers 6-8, graph database and consumers:** a graph DB (e.g. Google Spanner Graph, or an open-source option) builds node/edge relationships. Codex and other agents query the graph first, getting precise context (exact Apex class, file, tests, effort estimate) without consuming LLM tokens.
- **Workflow:** a PM creates a Jira story enriched with change context; when the developer/SCM moves it to "In Progress", code is generated and pushed to the dev environment. Humans approve promotion to higher environments.
- The framework up to the graph DB already exists as a generic POC (IG Labs) and a similar context pipeline is being discussed with J&J; a demo is available.

Erin framed it as an **elevation, not a replacement**: Codex won't invent relationships that aren't in the graph, people keep final approval, and developer time shifts from tracing dependencies and writing boilerplate Apex/tests to reviewing generated change plans and owning design decisions.

4. The pivot: efficiency vs. transformation

- Jose liked the architecture but said it doesn't change his delivery model. PM, architect, developer and QA still work in sequence with handoffs; it only gives each role a 20-30% efficiency boost.
- Sandeep suggested fewer devs/SCMs would be needed, with one reviewer deciding what moves to dev and a QA validating early on.
- Erin acknowledged the delivery model doesn't change much and cautioned against jumping straight to full organizational change, since few companies have done it. Jose agreed change must be phased, but insisted on knowing the end state first.
- Analogies: Jose wants to know the destination (Chicago, Kansas City or New York), not just the next train stop. Erin reframed it as train vs. airplane. Jose: everyone else is offering "the same horse with wheels."

5. Outcomes and next steps

- Insight Global will build a bold, "art of the possible" future-state vision for AI-native delivery, comparing what hyperscalers and big tech (OpenAI, Anthropic, etc.) are doing, and bring in additional experts (Sandeep, Nur, Vish, Yash).
- Run that in parallel with near-term efficiency wins (the knowledge-graph context layer), which buys Jose time to land the larger vision.
- Jose will share reference URLs on published AI delivery models and review the deck Erin emailed.
- Open item: guidance on moving local agents to the cloud and the skill sets required. This was not covered in depth.
- Erin will update Jose next week on when to expect the vision (likely not ready by next week).

Part 2: Summary of Jose's Perspective

Jose came in as a change agent, not a buyer of tools. His central message: **incremental AI efficiency is table stakes; he needs a materially different way of delivering software.**

What he wants

- **A new delivery model, not faster pockets.** Speeding up PRDs, HLDs, coding and QA separately keeps the same sequential, handoff-heavy model that's been used for 50 years. He wants to break that structure.
- **An AI-native, agent-orchestrated way of working.** Modeled on how AI companies ship: people play multiple roles, while sets of architect, developer and QA agents do the work with company-wide context (Google Cloud, Salesforce, 3,000+ applications), and humans orchestrate and verify, possibly cross-checking one model's output (e.g. Claude for planning) with another (Codex/OpenAI).
- **A clear end state first.** He accepts phased change management but wants to know the destination before choosing the next step.
- **Cloud-ready agents.** A practical path and the skill sets needed to move agents from developers' laptops into shared cloud environments, a capability he says his team lacks today.
- **No sales pitch.** Ideas and strategy first; tooling only where the ROI is clear.

How he defines success (team level)

- **Speed with the same staff.** Deliver much faster without cutting people; reduce OpEx and contractor spend rather than headcount.
- **Concrete benchmark (PDN team):** a new SMS template plus a Marketing Cloud journey branch for another market currently takes about two weeks (sometimes far longer). He wants it done in **half a day**.
- **Experiment and fail fast internally:** use AI for better testing so mistakes are caught before an SMS reaches a patient.
- **Hit company goals:** the team is behind on goals (e.g. readmissions) because delivery is too slow, which he blames on team and organizational operations.

Why he is pushing so hard

- **Differentiation:** many Ascension directors are hearing the same efficiency pitch from many vendors. Repeating it makes him "just another soldier"; he wants to be "the general."
- **Career risk:** if he only delivers a 20% gain, a firm like Deloitte, BCG or McKinsey will sell executives a bigger idea and replace his team's approach.
- **Executive pressure:** Ascension executives hear big promises from Salesforce and OpenAI and say "I want that"; his job is to make that real.
- **Hidden costs of the status quo:** more tools and custom code raise operating cost and add breaking points without reducing spend.
- **Cautionary examples:** Facebook's and Edward Jones's abrupt cuts that were reversed show what to avoid. Still, doing nothing is not an option.

His stance in one line

"I will die on the hill of a proposal being so outrageous and unrealistic that we might not materialize it, rather than die in the valley where everyone else is dying with the exact same idea."

He wants Insight Global to present a bold but credible vision, plus near-term wins, that he can use to convince and align his directors on a new operating model.